

The Role of Mothers' and Fathers' Perfectionistic Concerns and Emotional Dysregulation in the Co-Occurrence between Work-Family Conflict and Parental Burnout

Abstract

Work-family conflict and parental burnout are two important and often co-occurring indicators of psychological maladjustment related to the parenting role. Whereas both have been studied in largely different research areas, the present study forwards the assumption that their co-occurrence may be explained by shared dispositional factors such as parental perfectionism and emotional dysregulation (Malivoire et al., 2019). In particular, the present study adds to existing literature by (a) exploring the role of perfectionistic concerns in (the co-occurrence of) work-family conflict and parental burnout, (b) examining the role of emotional dysregulation as an intermediate variable in this link between perfectionism and parental maladjustment, and (c) addressing these research objectives for mothers ($N=116$) and fathers ($N=102$) separately, as well as their mutual influences using Actor-Partner Interdependence Modeling (APIM). The research goals are examined in families of adolescents, thereby addressing parental experiences during one of the most challenging periods of parenthood. The results based on both maternal and paternal self-report showed that perfectionistic concerns were related to both work-family conflict and parental burnout, with emotional dysregulation playing a significant intermediate role. In addition to these actor effects, the APIM results showed a significant partner-effect between paternal perfectionistic concerns and maternal work-family conflict, as well as between maternal perfectionistic concerns and paternal burnout. From an applied perspective, these findings suggest that interventions towards parents who struggle with work-family balance should not only focus on a more realistic and compassionate attitude towards themselves, but should also target emotion regulation, and enhance insight in transactional processes between partners.

Key words: Work-family Conflict, Parental Burnout, Perfectionistic Concerns, Emotional Dysregulation

Highlights

- Work-family conflict and parental burnout are two important aspects of parental functioning that often co-occur
- Parental perfectionistic concerns is a shared dispositional risk factor for both domains of parental functioning
- The link between perfectionistic concerns and ill-being can partly be explained by emotional dysregulation
- One parent's perfectionistic concerns does not only affect the parent's own functioning but also the psychosocial adjustment of the other parent.
- Interventions on work-family conflict and parental burnout should not only focus on a more realistic attitude towards parenting standards, but also target parents' capacity for emotion regulation.

The Role of Mothers' and Fathers' Perfectionistic Concerns and Emotional Dysregulation in the Co-Occurrence between Work-Family Conflict and Parental Burnout

Research on parental maladjustment increasingly focuses on work-family conflict (Greenhaus et al., 2006) and parental burnout (Mikolajczak et al., 2019) as two important sources of parental burden. Although work-family conflict and parental burnout have typically been investigated in separate research areas, there is a significant association between both experiences (e.g., Van Bakel et al., 2018). This association is plausible when considered from the 'Balances Between Risks and Resources' perspective (Mikolajczak & Roskam, 2018), according to which both work-family conflict and parental burnout stem from a perceived mismatch between parenting-related demands and the availability of resources to meet those demands. The purpose of the present study is to gain deeper insight in possible shared dispositional correlates of work-family conflict and parental burnout, that may explain why experiences of work-family conflict and parental burnout co-occur. Specifically, perfectionistic concerns are proposed here as a candidate vulnerability factor. The relevance of this maladaptive trait can be understood from the finding that especially in the context of parenthood, and more particularly in combining a professional role with family life, the high standards of perfectionistic parents are often unrealistic, hence increasing the risk to experience heightened and prolonged negative emotions and feelings of exhaustion in response to demands (e.g., Frost et al., 1995). The process through which this cascade of negative emotional experiences evolves has been described by Malivoire et al. (2019), who suggested that emotional dysregulation is an important intermediate process-based mechanism that accounts for the link between maladaptive perfectionism and parental maladjustment. This conceptual reasoning holds an important question on the etiology and co-occurrence of maladaptive parenting states, but has not been addressed empirically in a systematic manner.

Parental Burnout and Work-Family Conflict: Two Sides of the Same Coin?

Parental burnout is a parental state characterized by exhaustion in taking care of children, emotional distancing from the child, and reduced personal self-efficacy with regard to parenting (Roskam et al., 2017). Work-family conflict arises when work and family are experienced as mutually incompatible in some respect, often due to limits in a person's time and energy (Goode, 1960; Greenhaus et al., 2006). Parental burnout has been associated with parental psychopathology, reduced quality of the partner relationship, and dysfunctional parenting (Mikolajczak et al., 2018; Mikolajczak et al., 2019). In a related vein, work-family conflict tends to be associated with decreased parental mental health (for a review see Greenhaus et al., 2006) and suboptimal parenting strategies (Cooklin et al., 2015; Cooklin et al., 2016).

Currently, the co-occurrence of burnout and work-family conflict has been largely demonstrated in the context of job burnout, with abundant research showing a link between employees' experienced work-family conflict and feelings of burnout in the job domain (for a meta-analysis see Reichl et al., 2014). Further, recent studies in the parenting domain showed that experiences of conflict between work and family also relate to parental burnout (e.g., Brenning et al., 2022; Van Bakel et al., 2018; Wang et al., 2022). Only few studies however have attempted to unravel common sources of influence on both parental experiences, such as specific parental maladaptive traits or transdiagnostic processes related to regulating and downsizing negative emotions (Kawamoto et al., 2018; Mitchelson, 2009).

Perfectionistic Concerns

Although previous studies have revealed that perfectionism is associated with burnout in job, sport, and education domains (Hill & Curran, 2016), it remained for a long time unclear whether the same is true for the parenting domain. Mitchelson and Burns (1998) were one of the first researchers showing that perfectionism was not only linked with job burnout and job stress, but also with stress at home, parental distress, and lower life satisfaction in career mothers. Further, a significant set of studies continued to show a link between parents' maladaptive perfectionism and decreased parental psychological well-being (Priel & Besser, 2000; Snell et al., 2005; Vliegen et al., 2006) as well as problematic parenting behaviors (Casalin et al., 2014; Dieleman et al., 2020; Snell et al., 2005; Soenens et al., 2005), and parental burnout (Furutani et al., 2020; Kawamoto et al., 2018; Lin et al., 2021; Raudasoja et al., 2022; Sorkkila & Aunola, 2020; Szczygieł et al., 2020). Corroborating this evidence on the overall relevance of parental perfectionism, the last decade witnessed a growth in studies on the role of particular aspects of parental perfectionism to understand parental burnout. In this regard, Mikolajczak, Aunola, Sorkkila and Roskam (2023) showed in their meta-analysis that the perfectionistic feature called 'perfectionistic concerns' was one of the strongest risk factors for parental burnout, thereby confirming earlier individual studies on the relevance of this particular trait (Furutani et al., 2020; Kawamoto et al., 2018; Lin et al., 2021).

Perfectionistic concerns involves excessive concerns about making mistakes, doubts about actions, and the feeling that others demand perfection (Blatt, 2004; Frost et al., 1990). This perfectionistic feature is particularly harmful in the domain of parenting, because parenting is a challenging endeavor that requires much flexibility and adaptational qualities (Crnic & Low, 2002), including the ability to deal with unexpected circumstances. These challenges are difficult to align with the basic tendencies of perfectionistic parents, who have a strong need for control, exhibit rigid behavioral patterns, and have unrealistic expectations about their

objectives as a parent. Especially in adolescence, a developmental period characterized by normative turmoil and a higher risk for psychological difficulties (Deković et al., 2004), parents often find themselves challenged to be flexible and adjust their expectations.

Likewise, maladaptive perfectionism and work-family conflict have shown to be meaningfully associated (Deuling & Burns, 2017; Mitchelson, 2009; Sarour & El Keshky, 2022). Thereby, perfectionism was found to be relevant in relation to work-family conflict beyond the effects of other personality traits (Mitchelson, 2009). Also here, perfectionistic concerns may be particularly at play and may likely disturb parents' perceived work-family balance, because combining different roles in which parents strive for perfection makes them feel that they cannot realize what they want because the other role interferes. Based on the evidence available, it is plausible to assume that perfectionistic concerns represents a shared dispositional risk factor for both parental burnout and work-family conflict. As both experiences may be perceived as a personal failure by perfectionistic parents, parental feelings of failure in one domain may have a reinforcing effect on the other domain. Accordingly, among parents scoring high on perfectionistic concerns, the association between work-family conflict and parental burnout could be more pronounced than among parents scoring lower on this trait.

Emotional Dysregulation: A Mechanism for Understanding the Link between Perfectionistic Concerns and Parental Outcomes?

As outlined in the model developed by Malivoire et al. (2019), maladaptive perfectionists experience heightened and prolonged negative affect when perfectionistic standards are not met, and emotional dysregulation may be one important mechanism that explains the link between perfectionism and decreased parental functioning. Emotional dysregulation refers to an individuals' tendency to be overwhelmed by emotions, with emotions being expressed in an impulsive and disorganized way (Gross, 2014; Roth et al., 2009). Dysregulation is harmful because it involves a lack of control over negative emotions, as exemplified by extreme emotional outbursts that can cause personal and interpersonal tension.

Maladaptive perfectionism as a personality characteristic may trigger emotional dysregulation because minor failures are often perceived as signs of overall personal inadequacy, in view of the high standards that are pursued (Malivoire et al., 2019). This perception may then result in negative affect and in a further increase in reactivity to stimuli and events. Individuals high on perfectionistic concerns hence experience more and prolonged negative emotions when their personal standards are threatened and they typically use more unhelpful emotion regulation strategies. For example, to avoid negative evaluations by others, negative emotions in response to failure are often suppressed until this is no longer possible and people feel overwhelmed by their

negative emotions (i.e., emotional dysregulation). Maladaptive perfectionists may even feel unmotivated at all to regulate their emotions based on the belief that they deserve to feel bad following failure. Previous research supported this assumed positive link between maladaptive perfectionism and emotional dysregulation (e.g., Aldea & Rice, 2006; Montano et al., 2016; Rice et al., 2018). With regard to the link between emotion regulation and parental functioning, recent research demonstrates the role of emotion regulation in both work-family conflict (e.g., Gonnelli et al., 2018; Suh et al., 2020) and parental burnout (e.g., Vertsberger et al., 2022; Yang et al., 2021). Further, Flett, Hewitt, Oliver, & Macdonald (2002) point to the need to consider emotional dysregulation among perfectionistic parents as an important parental psychological vulnerability factor that hinders balanced parenting. However, no studies to date, addressed the intervening role of emotional dysregulation in effects of maladaptive perfectionism in the parenting domain.

The overall rationale for the present study can be understood along this road, as we expect, based on theory (Malivoire et al., 2019) and previous research, that emotional dysregulation plays an intermediate role in the link between perfectionistic concerns and both work-family conflict and parental burnout. The co-occurrence between both parental experiences may then be understood as an outcome of a their shared deficit in emotion regulation when dealing with the high parenting standards they are pursuing.

A Gender-Specific Approach with Actor-Partner Effects for Understanding Work-Family Conflict and Parental Burnout

Much previous research in the work-family domain focused on mothers (Cho & Ciancetta, 2016; Mikolajczak et al., 2023), which may question the generalizability of findings to fathers. While work-family conflict and parental burnout seem to affect both mothers and fathers (Roskam & Mikolajczak, 2020), there are mean differences based on gender in the occurrence of both domains of parental maladjustment. Thereby, mothers score generally higher on parental burnout (Roskam, Brianda, & Mikolajczak, 2018) and work-family conflict (Cinamon & Rich, 2002) compared to fathers. Next to mean gender differences, research also shows differences in the manifestation of co-occurrent psychopathology depending on parents' gender (see e.g., Mikolajczak et al., 2023). These results, showing that maternal data cannot be directly extended to fathers, point to the importance of research objectives for mothers and fathers separately.

Further, a growing body of research stresses the possibility of carry-over effects between parents, with characteristics of one parent affecting the other parent (see e.g., Brenning et al., 2017). An Actor Partner Interdependence Model (APIM; Kenny et al., 2006) allows to estimate actor effects (e.g., effects of one parent's perfectionistic concerns on this parent's own work-family conflict) as well as partner effects (e.g., effects of one

parent's perfectionistic concerns on the other parent's work-family conflict). Personality characteristics and emotion regulation of one partner in the family may indeed not only influence the experiences of this partner but also have cross-over effects to the experiences of the other partner. Although no previous study directly investigated this hypothesis, previous research did find partner effects between perfectionism (Stoeber, 2012) and emotion regulation (Mazzuca et al., 2019; Riahi et al., 2020) on the one hand, and parental well-being (e.g., marital satisfaction) on the other hand. Further, based on the literature on partner similarity (e.g., Anderson et al., 2003; Gonzaga et al., 2007), similarities between partners regarding personality characteristics, emotion regulation and parental well-being are expected.

The Present Study

The main objectives of the present study (see Figure 1) are threefold. First, the present study aims to investigate the role of parental perfectionistic concerns in understanding (the co-occurrence of) work-family conflict and parental burnout, thereby corroborating the broad literature on perfectionism and parenting outcomes. Next to the direct link between perfectionistic concerns and parental maladjustment, the present study considers the possibility that perfectionistic concerns amplify the strength of the association between both domains of parental functioning.

Second, we aim to investigate the role of emotional dysregulation as an intermediate process through which parental perfectionistic concerns develop into negative parental experiences, thereby translating proposed conceptual assumptions (Malivoire et al., 2019) into an empirical question. Further, we also consider the possibility that dysregulation amplifies the strength of the association between both domains of parental functioning.

Third, we aim to explore the generalizability of findings across parents and to examine carry-over effects between parents, thereby moving beyond the literature that considers parents as a dyad and acknowledging the uniqueness of both parenting partners and their interpersonal dynamics. On a subsample of families where both parents participated, the present study aimed to examine actor and partner effects. Using APIM, the present study aims to explore whether perfectionistic concerns and emotional dysregulation in one parent relates to more parental maladjustment in the other partner. Indeed, characteristics of one partner in the family (e.g., perfectionistic concerns) may not only influence the experiences of this partner but also have cross-over effects to the experiences of the other partner (Kenny, 2018).

Figure 1 about here

Method

Participants and Procedure

The sample consisted of Dutch-speaking Caucasian mothers ($N = 116$) and fathers ($N = 102$) that were contacted through two secondary schools in Flanders (Belgium). Parents were invited to participate during a parent-teacher conference. Specifically, an advertising stand was placed in the entrance hall of the school to recruit all mothers and fathers that combine work and family life. Parents could start filling out the questionnaires (see Measures section) while waiting for their appointment. If the questionnaire could not be finalized at school, it was further completed at home and returned in a sealed envelope. Ethical approval for this study was granted by the organizing university's Institutional Review Board (IRB).

The sample ($N = 127$ families) included families where both parents participated ($n = 91$) as well as families where only mother ($n = 25$) or only father ($n = 11$) participated in the study. Families in which both mothers and fathers participated were not systematically different on any of the study variables from those in which either mothers or fathers took part (Wilk's Lambda = .97; $F(4, 209) = 1.45$, $p > .05$). Because not all families included both parents, we first performed separate analyses on the paternal and maternal data. In a second step, we performed additional analyses on the subsample of 91 families in which both parents participated. Maternal and paternal variables were thereby included simultaneously using an Actor-Partner Interdependence Model (Kenny et al., 2006). With regard to missing data, the Little's missing completely at random (MCAR) test turned out to be not significant [$\chi^2(15)$ of 9.03, $p > .05$]. This non-significant result indicates that the data were likely to be missing at random. Cases with missing values were included in the analyses using full-information maximum likelihood estimation (FIML; Little & Rubin, 1987).

Mothers had a mean age of 44.35 years ($SD = 5.56$; range 30 to 60 years). Regarding level of education, 16.5% of the mothers earned a university degree, 49.6% had a (non-university) higher education degree, 31.3% had a diploma of secondary education and 2.6% had a diploma of primary education. The majority of mothers (80.2 percent) was married or lived together with their partner, whereas the other mothers were divorced and single ($N = 12$), divorced and in a new relationship ($N = 10$) or were widows ($N = 1$). With regard to number of children, 13.5 percent of the participants indicated that they had one child, 40.5 percent of the sample had two children, 18.9% had three children whereas 27% had four or more children. Children (69.6% girls) had a mean age of 14.72 years ($SD = 1.58$; range 11 to 18 years). Regarding work, hours at work of the participating mothers ranged from 10 to 70 hours per week ($M = 35.35$, $SD = 12.40$).

Fathers had a mean age of 46.84 years ($SD = 6.69$; range 32 to 76 years). Regarding level of education, 15.7% of the fathers earned a university degree, 35.3% had a (non-university) higher education degree, 45.1% had a diploma of secondary education and 3.9% had a diploma of primary education. The majority of fathers (87.3 percent) were married or lived together with their partner, whereas the other fathers were divorced and single ($N = 3$), divorced and in a new relationship ($N = 9$) or were widowers ($N = 1$). With regard to number of children, 7.3% of the participants indicated that they had one child, 41.5 % of the sample had two children, 29.3% had three children whereas 22% had four or more children. Children (75.3% girls) had a mean age of 14.72 years ($SD = 1.60$; range 11 to 18 years). Regarding work, hours at work of the participating fathers ranged from 15 to 80 hours per week ($M = 43.07$, $SD = 11.22$).

Measures

Perfectionistic Concerns

Perfectionistic concerns were measured using a short version of the ‘Concern over Mistakes’ subscale (four items, Lavrijsen et al., 2021) from the Frost Multidimensional Perfectionism Scale (F-MPS; Frost et al., 1990). Items read “If I don’t do as well as others, I’m worth less as a person”, “If I do not do well all the time, people will not respect me”, “People will probably think less of me if I make a mistake”, and “The fewer mistakes I make, the more people will like me”. These items, tapping into excessive concerns about making mistakes or worry that even minor failures would disappoint others, were shown to be prime indicators of maladaptive perfectionism (e.g., Dunkley et al., 2003; Frost et al., 1993; Mitchell-Parker et al., 2018). All items were rated on a 5-point Likert scale, varying from 1 (*totally disagree*) to 5 (*totally agree*). Despite the limited number of items, acceptable levels of reliability have been established in previous research (e.g., Lavrijsen et al., 2021). Cronbach’s alpha in the present study was .83 and .85 for perfectionistic concerns in mother and fathers, respectively.

Work-Family Conflict

To capture work-family conflict, we used the ‘Multidimensional measure of work-family conflict’ designed by Carlson et al. (2000) tapping into both work interference with family and family interference with work. In order to reduce participant burden, we limited the number of items from this scale to 12 (instead of using the original 18-item version). Using this shortened version of the scale, we tapped into time- and strain-based work-family conflict, two forms of conflict that were found relevant in relation to feelings of parental burnout (Brenning et al., 2022). Specifically, three items tapped into time-based work interference with family (e.g., “My work keeps me from my family activities more than I would like”), three items into time-based family

interference with work (e.g., “The time I spend on family responsibilities often interfere with my work responsibilities”), three items tapped into strain-based work interference with family (e.g., “When I get home from work I am often too frazzled to participate in family activities/responsibilities”) and three items into strain-based family interference with work (e.g., “Due to stress at home, I am often preoccupied with family matters at work”). Parents were asked to indicate on a 5 point Likert scale (1 = *completely disagree* to 5 = *completely agree*) to what extent they agreed with each statement. Cronbach’s alpha in the present study was .84 and .86 for mother and fathers, respectively.

Parental Burnout

For the measurement of feelings of parental burnout, we used eight items from the Parental Burnout Assessment (Roskam et al., 2018). To avoid over-questioning parents and to reduce the risk of missing data, we limited the number of items from this scale to 8 (instead of 23). This selection was made on the basis of previous analyses on data from the International Investigation of Parental Burnout, with the selected items displaying the strongest item-total correlations and still representing the different dimensions of parental burnout (IIPB study; $N = 453$, Schrooyen et al., 2019). The questionnaire examines emotional exhaustion in parents (3 items, e.g., “I have the sense that I’m really worn out as a parent”), contrast in parental self (2 items, e.g., “I don’t think I’m the good father/mother that I used to be to my child(ren)”), and saturation (3 items, e.g., “I can’t stand my role as father/mother any more”). Items were rated on a 7-point Likert scale, ranging from “*never*” to “*every day*”. Internal consistency was excellent for this scale with Cronbach’s alpha of .94 and .90 for mothers and fathers, respectively.

Emotional Dysregulation

To tap into emotional dysregulation, we used the dysregulation subscale from the Emotion Regulation Inventory (ERI; Roth et al., 2009). Four (out of the original six) items were selected, which showed good validity and internal consistency in previous research (e.g., Brenning et al., 2020). A sample item reads “It is hard for me to control my sad emotions”. A Likert scale, ranging from 1 (*completely not true*) to 5 (*completely true*), was used for this questionnaire. Previous research has provided evidence for the internal structure and validity of the instrument (Roth et al., 2009). Cronbach’s alphas in the current study were .79 and .72 for mothers and fathers, respectively.

Data Analyses

To examine the main research questions we conducted a series of path analyses using Mplus 8 (Muthén & Muthén, 2012). We evaluated model fit based on a combined consideration of the Chi-square statistic (χ^2), the

Comparative Fit Index (CFI), the Root Mean Square Error of Approximation (RMSEA) and the Standardized Root-Mean-square Residual (SRMR). The χ^2 should be as small as possible. A CFI value of .90 or higher indicates a reasonable fit, whereas a RMSEA value of .06 or lower and a SRMR value of .08 or lower indicate acceptable fit (Kline, 2010). Bootstrapping was used to test the level of significance for indirect effects (e.g., Mallinckrodt et al., 2006). The bootstrap method is a data resampling procedure to empirically create bootstrap samples from the original data. The confidence interval (CI) is used to determine whether the indirect effects are significant. A total of 1000 bootstrap samples were created and a 95% CI was used to examine the significance of our indirect effect estimates. When the 95% CI does not include zero, the indirect effect is considered significant at the .05 level.

Results

Preliminary Analyses

Correlations among study variables are presented in Table 1. As expected, both mothers' and fathers' perfectionistic concerns correlated positively with parental feelings of work-family conflict and feelings of parental burnout. Both domains of parental functioning were also mutually correlated. Further, emotional dysregulation correlated positively with perfectionistic concerns, work-family conflict, and parental burnout.

Gender differences were inspected with regard to the mean scores on the main study variables. Scores for parental burnout significantly differed ($t(215) = -2.05, p < .05$) between mothers ($M = 1.89; SD = 1.14$) and fathers ($M = 1.61; SD = 0.85$), as did the mean scores for emotional dysregulation ($t(214) = -2.76, p < .01$) between mothers ($M = 2.57; SD = 0.88$) and fathers ($M = 2.27; SD = 0.73$). No significant gender differences were found with regard to the mean scores on parental perfectionistic concerns ($t(215) = -1.57, p = .12$) nor work-family conflict ($t(215) = -1.65, p = .10$).

Table 1 about here

Next, we investigated correlations between the study variables and potentially confounding variables (i.e., parents' age, education level, working hours per week, family status, number of children, children's gender and age). Only one of these variables was significantly related to the key study variables, that is, fathers' working hours per week (Wilk's Lambda = .83; $F(4, 77) = 3.92, p < .01$). More specifically, the number of working hours of fathers is significantly related to more work-family conflict ($r = .22, p < .05$) and less emotional dysregulation ($r = -.23, p < .05$). For mothers, none of the confounding variables was related to the key study variables. With regard to maternal working hours however, a marginally significant link was found (Wilk's Lambda = .92; $F(4, 88) = 2.00, p = .10$). More specifically, maternal working hours was related to

perfectionistic concerns ($r = .17, p = .08$). Based on these analyses, we controlled for the effect of working hours in all subsequent analyses.

The Role of Perfectionistic Concerns in Work-Family Conflict and Parental Burnout

In a first step (see Figure 2), we examined the link between perfectionistic concerns and both work-family conflict and parental burnout, as well as the association between the latter two study variables. Further, we investigated whether the strength of the association between work-family conflict and parental burnout was moderated by perfectionistic concerns. Estimation of this model showed good model fit for mothers ($\chi^2(9) = 49.99, p < 0.01$; CFI = 1.00; RMSEA = .00; SRMR = .05) and fathers ($\chi^2(9) = 31.83, p < 0.01$; CFI = 1.00; RMSEA = .00; SRMR = .04). The results showed a significant association between perfectionistic concerns and work-family conflict ($\beta = .31, p < .001$ and $\beta = .20, p < .05$ for mothers and fathers respectively), and between perfectionistic concerns and parental burnout ($\beta = .31, p < .05$ and $\beta = .31, p < .01$ for mothers and fathers respectively). Work-family conflict and parental burnout were also significantly correlated ($\beta = .53, p < .001$ and $\beta = .36, p < .001$ for mothers and fathers respectively). However, the strength of association between work-family conflict and parental burnout was not moderated by perfectionistic concerns ($\beta = .16, p = .12$ and $\beta = .13, p = .14$ for mothers and fathers respectively).

Figure 2 about here

The Role of Emotional Dysregulation in the Link between Perfectionistic Concerns and Both Work-Family Conflict and Burnout

Second, we investigated emotional dysregulation as an intermediate variable in the link between perfectionistic concerns and both work-family conflict and burnout (see Figure 3). Estimation of this model showed good model fit for mothers ($\chi^2(14) = 74.86, p < 0.01$; CFI = 1.00; RMSEA = .01; SRMR = .06) and fathers ($\chi^2(14) = 64.97, p < 0.01$; CFI = 1.00; RMSEA = .03; SRMR = .05). The results showed a significant link between perfectionistic concerns and emotional dysregulation ($\beta = .37, p < .001$ and $\beta = .40, p < .001$ for mothers and fathers respectively). In turn, emotional dysregulation showed a significant association with work-family conflict ($\beta = .24, p < .01$ and $\beta = .41, p < .001$ for mothers and fathers respectively) and parental burnout ($\beta = .24, p < .001$ and $\beta = .23, p < .01$ for mothers and fathers respectively). There was also a significant association between work-family conflict and parental burnout ($\beta = .48, p < .001$ and $\beta = .31, p < .01$ for mothers and fathers respectively). However, the strength of association between work-family conflict and parental burnout was not moderated by emotional dysregulation ($\beta = .06, p = .59$ and $\beta = -.03, p = .71$ for mothers and fathers respectively). Further, the initial associations between perfectionism and both work-family conflict and

parental burnout decreased to some extent. Although the link between perfectionistic concerns and parental burnout ($\beta = .24, p < .01$; $\beta = .24, p < .05$ for mothers and fathers respectively) and the link between mothers' perfectionistic concerns and work-family conflict ($\beta = .22, p < .01$) remained significant, the association between fathers' perfectionistic concerns and work-family conflict turned to non-significance ($\beta = .04, p = .68$).

Figure 3 about here

Next, we tested whether the indirect pathways from perfectionism to work-family conflict and parental burnout via emotional dysregulation were significant (Preacher & Hayes, 2008). The results show a significant indirect path from perfectionistic concerns to work-family conflict via emotional dysregulation for both mothers ($\beta = .09, p < .05$, [95% CI: 0.02, 0.16]) and fathers ($\beta = .16, p < .01$, [95% CI: 0.04, 0.29]), as well as a significant path from perfectionistic concerns to parental burnout via dysregulation for both mothers ($\beta = .09, p < .05$, [95% CI: 0.02, 0.16]) and fathers ($\beta = .09, p < .05$, [95% CI: 0.02, 0.16]).

Actor-Partner Effects in the Link between Perfectionistic Concerns, Emotional Dysregulation and Parental Experiences

Figure 4 provides a visual depiction of the model investigating actor and partner effects between parental perfectionistic concerns and parental well-being. The structural model showed a good fit ($\chi^2(27) = 121.40, p < 0.01$; CFI = .98; RMSEA = .06; SRMR = .05). Perfectionistic concerns displayed significant actor effects on work-family conflict and parental burnout for both mothers and fathers. In addition, there was a significant partner effect of maternal perfectionistic concerns on paternal burnout and from paternal perfectionistic concerns on maternal work-family conflict.

Figure 4 about here

Figure 5 displays the actor and partner effects in the (indirect) links between perfectionism, emotional dysregulation and the parental experiences. The structural model showed an acceptable fit ($\chi^2(44) = 197.89, p < 0.01$; CFI = .92; RMSEA=.09; SRMR = .07). Both for mothers and fathers, perfectionistic concerns were linked to more work-family conflict and parental burnout via maternal dysregulation. No partner effects were found in these indirect associations.

Figure 5 about here

Discussion

Research on parental adjustment increasingly focuses on parental burnout, a condition characteristic of parents who feel depleted in their parenting role, which increases the risk for mental health problems and

dysfunctional interactions with their children (see e.g., Mikolajczak et al., 2019). Further, research has shown a linkage between parental burnout and work-family conflict (e.g., Van Bakel et al., 2018), a plausible association when considering the ‘Balances Between Risks and Resources’ perspective (Mikolajczak & Roskam, 2018). The main aim of the present study was to investigate the role of parents’ maladaptive perfectionism in the co-occurrence of both outcomes. Further, based on a conceptual model recently proposed by Malivoire et al. (2019), the present study investigated emotional dysregulation as an intermediate variable in the association between perfectionistic concerns and parental experiences. A unique feature of this study is that it included both maternal and paternal data (Mikolajczak et al., 2023), allowing for an investigation of the hypotheses across parental gender and even for cross-over effects between partners using Actor-Partner Interdependence Modeling (Kenny et al., 2006). Further, the study focuses on parents of adolescents, as adolescence may be a particularly challenging developmental periode for perfectionistic parents.

In line with previous evidence, the results showed that parents high on perfectionistic concerns indeed experience more feelings of parental burnout (Kawamoto et al., 2018) and struggle more in combining work and family roles (Mitchelson, 2009). In addition to this established evidence, the current results suggest that this trait-based etiology of parental burnout and work-family conflict holds across mothers and fathers. This finding is interesting as it may represent an important societal shift in work-family organization, where fathers have become more important actors in the work-family balance (Townsend, 2002). Indeed, due to the rise of dual-earner families, and important changes in favor of gender equality, today’s employed fathers tend to have substantial household responsibilities in addition to work obligations (Allen et al., 2000). As such, striving to meet goals in the domains of both breadwinning and involved fathering, men report increasing conflicts between their work and family demands (Townsend, 2002; Winslow, 2005) as well as feelings of parental burnout (Roskam & Mikolajczak, 2020). Although some studies still found a higher average level of parental burnout among mothers (Roskam & Mikolajczak, 2020), as was the case in the present study, the same antecedent mechanisms seem to be at work in both maternal and paternal feelings of parental burnout. The current findings similarly indicate a detrimental role of parental perfectionistic concerns and emotional dysregulation across parental gender. Future research should however further disentangle potential gender effects in the role of parental perfectionism and emotional dysregulation. For instance, previous research found that mothers scored higher on societal-oriented parenting perfectionism than fathers, whereas fathers scored higher on self-oriented parenting perfectionism than mothers (Lee et al., 2012). Governmental policies can play an important role in this regard (Meeussen & Van Laar, 2018). For example, when mothers receive much more parental leave than fathers

after the birth of a child, this may signal a social norm of mothers as those primarily responsible for taking care of the children.

Further, the APIM results showed that parental perfectionism is associated with some of the parental experiences of the other parent. Indeed, next to several actor effects, perfectionistic concerns displayed two significant partner effects (see Figure 4). The first significant partner effect showed that perfectionistic concerns in mothers did not only relate to their own feelings of work-family conflict and parental burnout but also to more parental burnout in fathers. Further, perfectionistic concerns in fathers did not only relate to their own parental experiences, but also to more work-family conflict in mothers. These partner effects suggest that constant strivings for perfection and a strong focus on failure in one partner could affect the other partner's parental functioning. More specifically, fathers may feel more inadequate, exhausted and possibly withdraw from the father role (i.e., three dimensions of parental burnout) when confronted with extremely high standards set by their partner. Part of this cross-over effect might be explained by mothers' other-oriented perfectionism towards fathers (Hewitt & Flett, 1991), a possibility that could be examined in future research. Mothers on the other hand may try to live up to their husbands' expectations by trying even harder to meet those extreme demands exceeding their own time and energy (resulting in more work-family conflict). This hypothesis is in line with recent research showing that although men are more involved in child rearing than before, there is still an imbalance between mothers and fathers, with the load of parenting being more often placed on mothers (Nomaguchi, & Milkie, 2020; Ruppanner et al., 2019). Future research should however investigate whether these specific links between one partner's perfectionistic concerns and respectively mothers' work-family conflict and fathers' feelings of parental burnout could be replicated and indeed indicate a possible gender difference. Apart from these two significant partner effects, all other partner links were not significant. Perhaps the statistical power of these analyses was rather limited. The sample used for the APIM analyses was rather small ($n = 91$ families where both parents participated) relative to the complexity of the model being estimated. As such, future research should include more mother-father dyads to increase statistical power. Further, we relied on a non-clinical sample of generally Caucasian families with relatively adaptive parental functioning. Future research in more diverse populations and clinical samples is needed to investigate actor-partner effects in individuals with more severe complaints of work-family conflict and parental burnout. It is also possible that more partner effects would be obtained in samples with higher levels of maladaptive perfectionism or stronger variability in emotional dysregulation.

From a process-based perspective, emotional dysregulation appeared to be a significant underlying factor for understanding the link between maladaptive perfectionism and both work-family conflict and parental burnout. The results, with both mothers and fathers, showed that perfectionistic concerns are related to both outcomes of parental functioning via emotional dysregulation. In line with previous research on the transdiagnostic value of emotion regulation (Aldao et al., 2016), these findings may inspire future prevention and intervention efforts. However, future research could also investigate other relevant processes and factors. Although the link between fathers' perfectionistic concerns and work-family conflict decreased to non-significance after inserting emotional dysregulation as an underlying process, other associations between maladaptive perfectionism and outcomes of parental experiences remained significant. Note that we indeed did not expect full mediation of the link between perfectionistic concerns and parental functioning. Concerns over mistakes may lead directly to a sense of incompetence and fatigue (i.e., two indicators of parental burnout). In addition, other mediators are likely to account for the association between perfectionistic concerns and parental functioning. An interesting direction for future research is to consider the role of alternative emotion regulation strategies (e.g., emotional suppression) as well as other possible candidates that were highlighted in the literature such as the role of stress and perceived social support (Dunkley et al., 2000). Further, no significant partner effects were found with regard to the underlying process of emotional dysregulation (see Figure 5). Although emotion regulation may mainly concern a process that takes place within oneself, this non significance of partner effects was rather unexpected. Previous research on the link between emotion regulation and partner well-being (Mazzuca et al., 2019; Riahi et al., 2020) did indeed find partner effects between emotion regulation and marital satisfaction. Although marital satisfaction as an outcome variable may be more prone to such partner effects (in comparison to outcomes of parental functioning such as work-family conflict and parental burnout), future research is needed before drawing firm conclusions. A larger and more heterogeneous sample could again allow for a stronger test of partner effects in the role of emotional dysregulation. Nonetheless, the APIM results showed similarities between partners in terms of dispositional tendencies of perfectionism and emotional dysregulation. In line with the literature on partner similarity (e.g., Anderson et al., 2003; Gonzaga et al., 2007), perfectionistic concerns and emotional dysregulation of mothers and fathers were indeed correlated.

Limitations and Directions for Future Research

Although this study had several methodological strengths, some limitations should also be discussed. First, the present study is based on cross-sectional data, which did not allow us to assess directionality. An important question for further research is to investigate the direction of effects in the current study's

hypothesized model. For example, as parental burnout may affect individuals' perceptions, it is possible that parents with decreased parental well-being are temporarily perceiving their own achievements as more negative than they usually do. This bias may explain some of the observed associations. Further, it makes conceptual sense that work-family conflict may contribute to emotional dysregulation and a stronger focus on failure. Longitudinal or experimental research is needed to test the direction of effects more adequately.

Second, this study was based on parents' self-reports but did not include data from other important sources, including partner report on spouses' functioning. It remains unclear whether the information provided on self-report questionnaires adequately reflects participants' actual thoughts, feelings and behaviors. Self-report measures mainly tap into conscious thoughts and ideas, which may increase the likelihood of self-presentational bias. Other methods (e.g., narratives) may capture unconscious feelings that self-report scales fail to measure. Further, the present self-report measures were rather limited in length. For example, when measuring perfectionistic concerns, only four items from the 'Concern over Mistakes' subscale were taken from the Frost Multidimensional Perfectionism Scale (F-MPS). Although the factor 'concern over mistakes' appears most central to the Frost concept of perfectionism, given that this subscale has stronger correlations with related constructs and contributes the most variance to the F-MPS (Mitchell-Parker et al., 2018), there is a need to revisit this topic in future research with multiple measures of perfectionism. Thereby, the role of socially prescribed perfectionism (e.g., Raudasoja et al., 2022; Sorkkila & Aunola, 2020) and other-oriented perfectionism (e.g., Lin et al., 2022) could be investigated next to the role of self-oriented perfectionism (including personal standards and doubts about actions). Further, when measuring work-family conflict, only two out of the three forms of conflict (i.e., time-based, strain-based, but no behavior-based conflict items) were included. Although behavior-based conflict (example items: "The problem-solving behaviors I use in my job are not effective in resolving problems at home") are theoretically the least relevant when studying the link with parental burnout (in comparison to the other forms of conflict), it would be interesting to include all forms of conflict in future research, and execute more fine-grained analyses differentiating between the different types of work-family conflict. Although choices were made in order to reduce participant burden, which is particularly important because the current study's APIM design requires both parents of the family to complete the survey, future research replicating the current study's results through more extensive self-report and alternative other-report measurements is important.

Third, the study is limited in terms of generalizability. Although data collection of the current study aimed for a broad target group, not all parents were willing to participate. As such, the relatively limited sample

size may have impeded statistical power to some extent, and may hence have played a role in our ability to find and reproduce existing effects. Future research should invest even more in the recruitment and follow-up of participants. Unfortunately, we do not have information on the current study's participation rate and possible selection effects. For example, parents who participated may have been those with the lowest emotional exhaustion scores (or the reverse may also be true), which may have led to an over- or under-estimation of the relationships. Further, as the current results were obtained in a rather homogeneous sample of parents who are mostly married or living together and have a relatively high socioeconomic status, future research should try to replicate and refine the findings in a more heterogeneous sample. Future research may also focus on families from a more diverse cultural context, children in different developmental periods (e.g., toddlerhood), and families with parents and children at risk for problem behavior. Further, child temperament may form a potentially important variable related to the present study variables as we might, for example, expect feelings of parental emotional exhaustion to be worse in those who have a child with more difficult temperamental traits.

Fourth, the present study focused only on perfectionistic concerns and dysregulation as two micro-level risk factors for parental well-being. According to a multilevel perspective of causes on parental burnout, meso- (e.g., inadequate parenting practices) and macro-level factors (e.g., social conditions and expectations that increase pressure on parents) could affect parental burnout next to these micro-level risk factors (Roskam et al., 2017). Future research is needed to understand how these factors interact at different levels of analysis.

Practical Implications

The results of the present study support the notion that parents' perfectionistic concerns are a risk factor for parental ill-being, a link that is explained partly by parents' heightened emotional dysregulation. Next to actor effects of maladaptive perfectionism on parental functioning, parent's perfectionistic concerns are related to some extent to their partner's experiences. As such, the current study underscores the importance of perfectionistic concerns and emotional dysregulation as important parental factors related to work-family conflict and parental burnout, two aspects of parental ill-being that often co-occur. Both perfectionism and emotion regulation may represent interesting targets for future prevention and intervention research with regard to parental ill-being. An integrated approach, which increases the setting of clearly defined and realistic expectations, a focus on what is achieved (instead of what isn't) as well as on parents' capacities to deal effectively with feelings of failure, has the potential to strengthen resilience in fundamental ways and to protect parents' against ill-being. Recent intervention research on parental burnout (Brianda et al., 2020) indeed showed promising results of an intervention guiding parents in decreasing their parenting stressors (including parental

perfectionism) and increasing their parenting resources (including the strengthening of emotion regulation abilities). Future intervention research could investigate whether this intervention also has positive effects on experienced work-family conflict. Further, as the present study's results show some evidence for cross-over effects between parents, future research could investigate the effects of this intervention on both parents and/or include a family module focusing on parental insight in transactional processes that can take place between partners.

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PERFECTIONISTIC CONCERNS AND PARENTAL WELL-BEING

Table 1

Means (M), Standard Deviations (SD), and Correlations between the study variables

	1	2	3	4	M (SD)
1. Perfectionistic concerns		.21*	.33**	.39***	2.15 (0.92)
2. Work-family conflict	.32**		.40***	.35***	2.34 (.65)
3. Parental burnout	.34***	.56***		.30**	1.61 (.85)
4. Dysregulation	.34***	.31**	.33***		2.27 (.73)
M (SD)	2.35 (0.94)	2.48 (0.62)	1.89 (1.14)	2.57 (0.88)	

Note. * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Mother-report data are below the diagonal whereas father-report data are above the diagonal.

PERFECTIONISTIC CONCERNS AND PARENTAL WELL-BEING

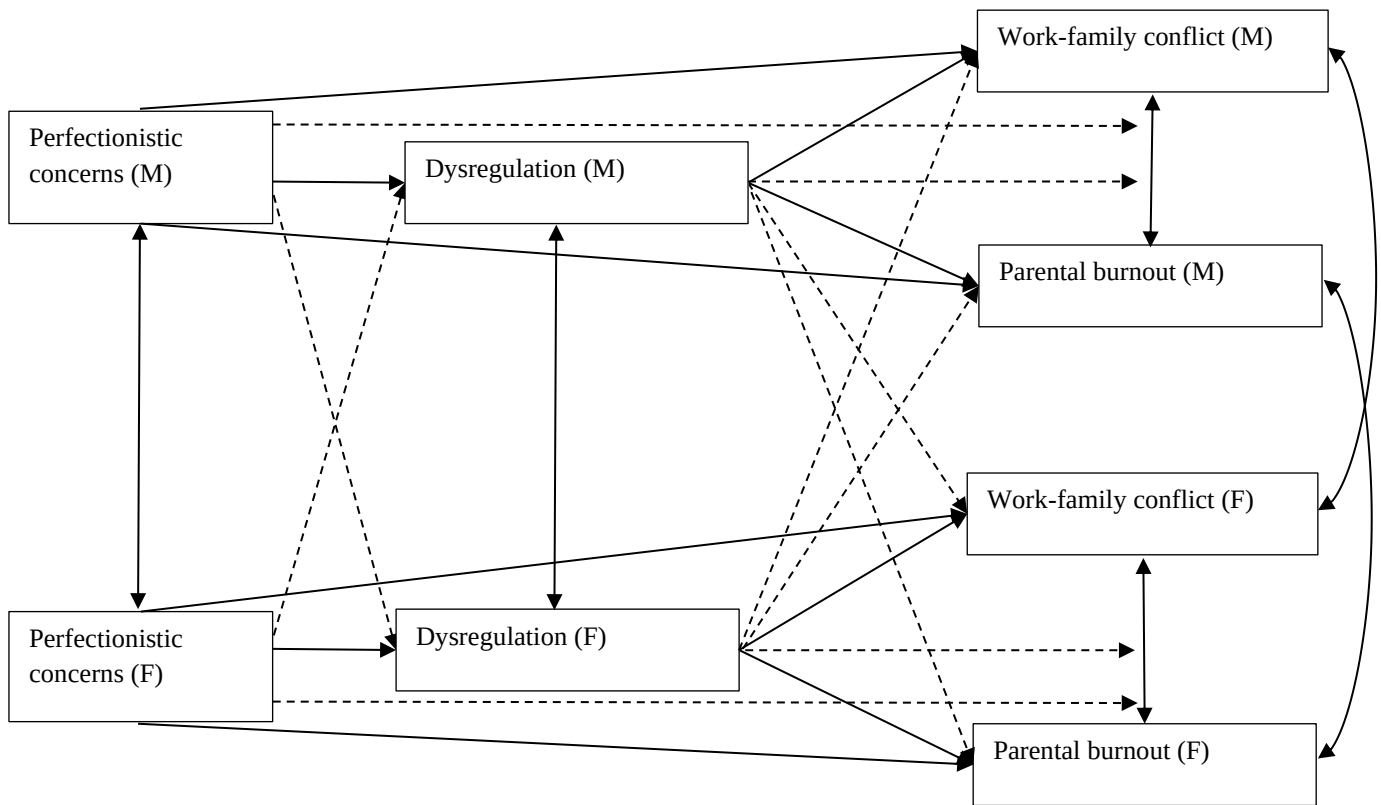


Figure 1. Conceptual model. M = Mother; F = Father.

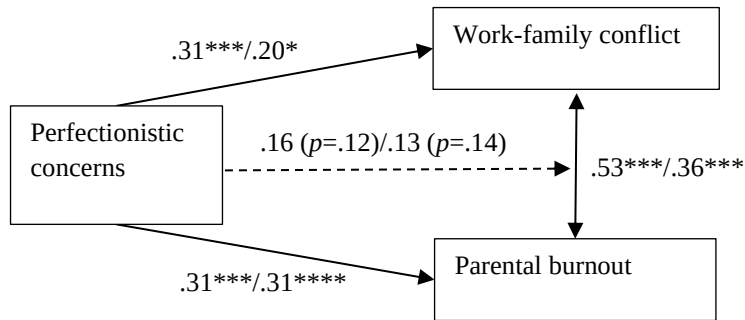


Figure 2. The role of maternal/paternal perfectionistic concerns in work-family conflict and parental burnout

Coefficients shown are standardized path coefficients, * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

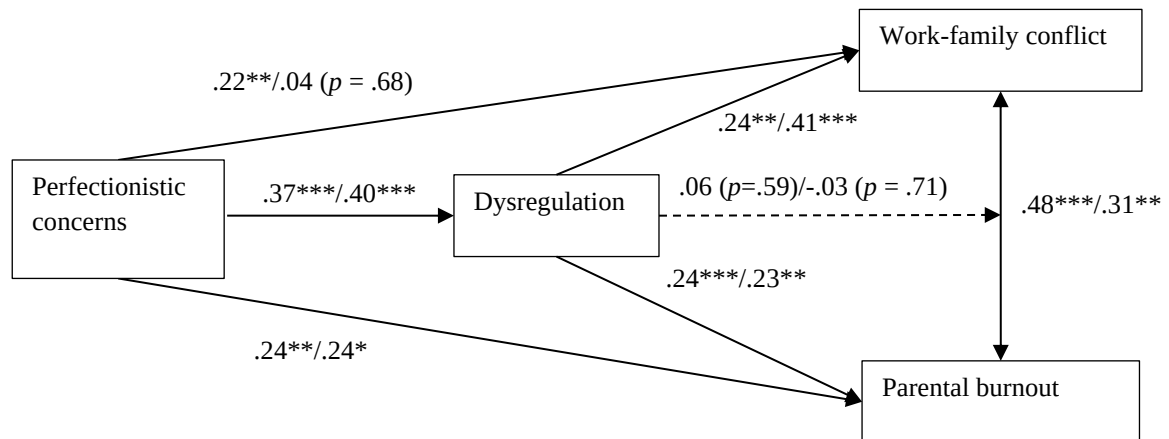


Figure 3. The role of maternal/paternal emotional dysregulation in the link between perfectionistic concerns and both work-family conflict and burnout

Coefficients shown are standardized path coefficients, * $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$

PERFECTIONISTIC CONCERNS AND PARENTAL WELL-BEING

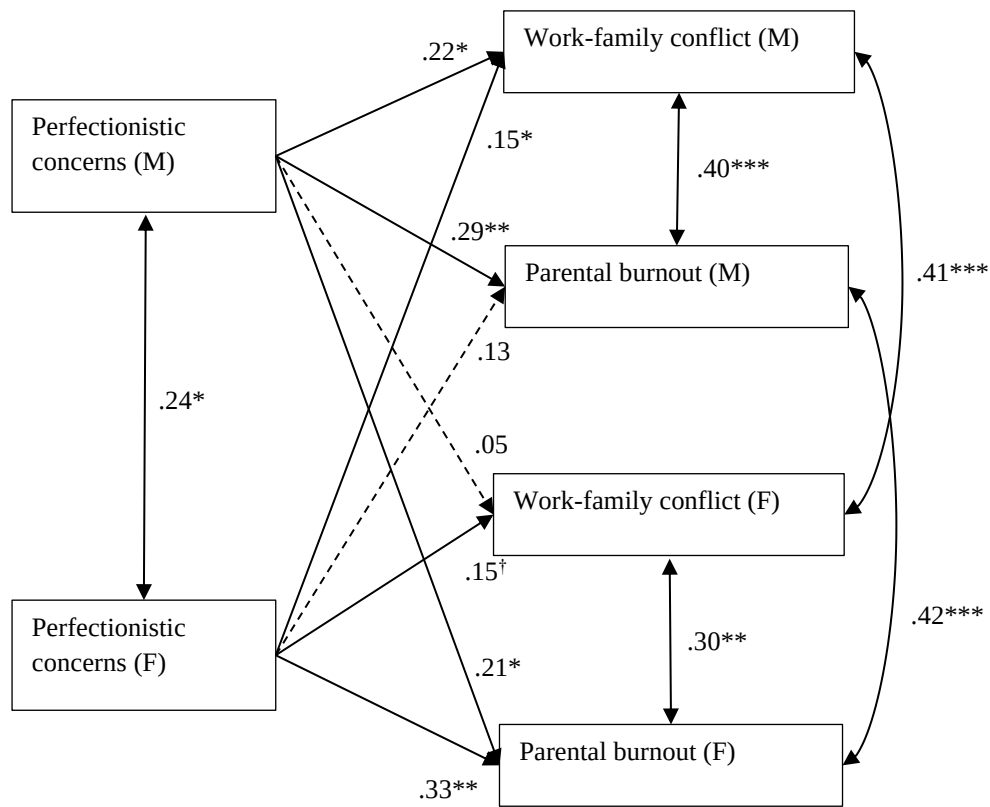


Figure 4. APIM model on the link between perfectionistic concerns and parental functioning. M = Mother; F = Father.

PERFECTIONISTIC CONCERNS AND PARENTAL WELL-BEING

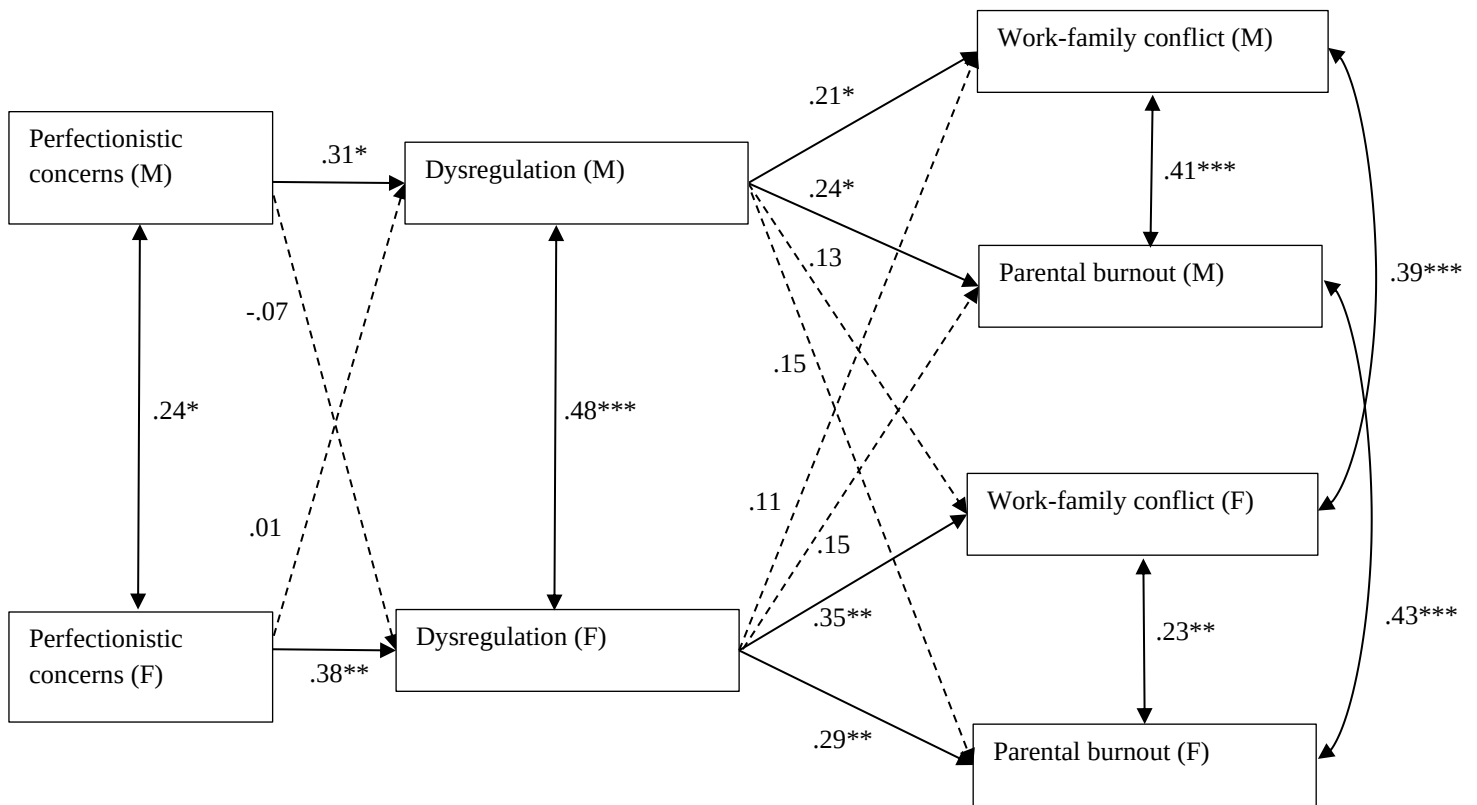


Figure 5. APIM model on the role of emotional dysregulation in the link between self-critical perfectionism and parental functioning. M = Mother; F = Father.